Domain-Specific Gender Gaps in Sexual Attitudes: The Sexual Double Standard, Gender Ideology, and the Cohort-Linked Feminization of Same-Sex Acceptance in China

[Blinded for Review]

Abstract

Research on gender differences in sexual attitudes typically treats men as the more permissive gender, but this characterization rests on heterosexual domains of sexuality. We pool seven waves of the Chinese General Social Survey (2012–2023; $N = 78{,}206$) to compare gender gaps across three domains: premarital sex, extramarital sex, and same-sex relations. The gender gap differs in direction across domains: men hold more permissive views toward premarital and extramarital sex, but women are more accepting of same-sex relations. Gender ideology mediates approximately 8–12% of the gap in the extramarital and same-sex domains but acts as a suppressor for premarital sex. Gender-stratified models reveal asymmetric patterns consistent with the sexual double standard: patriarchal ideology is associated with men's tolerance of extramarital sex but with women's disapproval of premarital sex. The same-sex gap is concentrated among post-1990 women and is associated with Internet use and education. These cross-sectional results demonstrate that sexual attitudes are domain-specific, that the same gender ideology produces different associations depending on the domain, and that cohort-linked patterns among young Chinese women signal a divergence from their

male peers in the moral evaluation of sexuality.

Keywords: sexual attitudes, gender gap, gender ideology, sexual double standard, same-sex acceptance, China

1 Introduction

Among Chinese adults born before 1960, men and women hold similar views on same-sex relations, premarital sex, and extramarital sex. For each successive birth cohort, however, these attitudes diverge: by the post-1990 generation, the gender gap in same-sex acceptance has widened by nearly half a point on a five-point scale relative to older cohorts, with young women far more accepting than young men. In the opposite direction, the gender gap in premarital sex attitudes has also widened, with young men increasingly more permissive than young women. The gender gap in sexual attitudes does not run in a single direction. It differs fundamentally across domains of sexuality, and it is growing (Figure 1).

This reversal poses a problem for existing theories of sexual attitudes. Research on gender differences in sexuality has consistently found that men express more permissive attitudes than women (Oliver and Hyde, 1993; Petersen and Hyde, 2010). But this finding rests overwhelmingly on heterosexual domains of sexuality: casual sex, premarital sex, extramarital affairs. When attitudes toward homosexuality are examined separately, a different pattern emerges (Hildebrandt and Jäckle, 2023; Zhou, 2022). If the gender gap in sexual attitudes were simply a matter of men being "more liberal," we would expect the gap to point in the same direction across all domains. It does not. Understanding why requires a domain-specific framework that traces different gender gaps to different mechanisms within the same gender system.

Sexual attitudes matter. They shape the social environment in which sexual minorities live, the policies that govern reproductive and partnership rights, and the intimate negotiations between partners over fidelity, desire, and moral boundaries. In China, where the state has oscillated between promoting and restricting public discourse on sexuality, understanding the gendered structure of sexual morality is critical for predicting the trajectory of both gender relations and LGBTQ acceptance. The rapid divergence in same-sex attitudes between young men and young women, concentrated in the years since 2017, signals a shift that will reshape the social landscape of Chinese sexuality.

Existing research on sexual attitudes in China has made important contributions. Gao and Wang (2025) documented age, period, and cohort patterns in sexual attitude change. Liu et al. (2020) identified the Internet as a driver of sexual liberalization. Zhou (2022) visualized the growing gender gap in same-sex attitudes using a decade of CGSS data. Hu and Li (2019) showed that traditional gender role beliefs suppressed tolerance of homosexuality. Yet no study has combined formal mediation analysis, gender-stratified models, and multi-wave interaction analyses to systematically trace how and why the gender gap operates differently across domains of sexual attitudes in China.

This paper addresses this gap. We pool seven waves of the Chinese General Social Survey (2012–2023; $N = 78{,}206$) to analyze gender differences in attitudes toward premarital sex, extramarital sex, and same-sex relations. We test gender ideology as a mediator of the gender gap using mediation analysis. We estimate gender-stratified models to reveal how patriarchal beliefs are associated with sexual attitudes differently for men and women, providing evidence consistent with the sexual double standard. And we map the heterogeneity of the gender gap across birth cohorts, education levels, Internet use, and marital status.

Three findings anchor the paper. First, the gender gap differs in direction across domains: women hold less permissive views on premarital and extramarital sex but are more accepting of same-sex relations. Second, gender ideology mediates the gap differently by domain, and gender-stratified models reveal asymmetric patterns consistent with the double standard: patriarchal ideology is associated with men's tolerance of extramarital sex but with women's disapproval of premarital sex. Third, the same-sex gap is a recent, cohort-linked phenomenon concentrated among post-1990 women and amplified by Internet use and education.

This paper makes three contributions. First, we provide a systematic analysis of domain-specific gender gaps in sexual attitudes using pooled multi-wave data, formal mediation analysis, and interaction models, building on the descriptive work of Hildebrandt and Jäckle (2023) and Zhou (2022) to show that the gap does not merely vary in magnitude but differs in direction. Second, we identify gender ideology as a domain-specific pathway that is associated

with the gender gap through mechanisms consistent with the sexual double standard, with different associations for men and women across attitude domains. Third, we document rapid cohort-linked patterns in same-sex acceptance among young Chinese women, a process associated with education, digital media, and egalitarian gender beliefs that has no parallel among young men.

2 Background and Theory

Sexual attitudes sit at the intersection of gender, morality, and social structure. How people evaluate premarital sex, extramarital sex, and same-sex relations reveals the normative boundaries a society draws around sexuality and the gendered logic through which those boundaries are enforced. A large cross-national literature documents that men express more sexually permissive attitudes than women (Oliver and Hyde, 1993; Petersen and Hyde, 2010, 2011). This finding is so consistent that it has hardened into a stylized fact: men are the permissive gender. Yet the evidence behind this generalization rests almost entirely on heterosexual domains of sexuality. When studies examine attitudes toward homosexuality separately, the pattern is less clear, and in some national contexts it reverses, with women expressing greater acceptance (Hildebrandt and Jäckle, 2023; Zhou, 2022). The possibility that the gender gap in sexual attitudes runs in different directions depending on the domain has received little systematic attention.

This paper takes domain specificity as its starting point. Rather than asking whether men or women are more sexually permissive in general, we ask how and why the gender gap differs across three domains: premarital sex, extramarital sex, and same-sex relations. We draw on the sexual double standard, gender ideology theory, moral foundations research, and the concept of the patriarchal bargain to develop a framework in which a single underlying gender system produces opposite gender gaps in different attitudinal domains. The Chinese case, with its combination of rapid modernization, persistent patriarchal family norms, and a

distinctive digital media ecology, provides a setting where these dynamics are particularly visible.

The Sexual Double Standard

The concept of the sexual double standard has anchored research on gendered sexuality for over six decades. Reiss (1960) first identified the asymmetric moral standards applied to men's and women's sexual behavior: the same acts that are tolerated or celebrated in men are condemned in women. Subsequent research confirmed the persistence of this asymmetry across historical periods and cultural contexts. Crawford and Popp (2003) reviewed two decades of studies and concluded that while experimental evidence for the double standard was uneven, qualitative and survey-based research consistently found that women's sexuality was subjected to greater scrutiny and harsher judgment than men's. They argued that the double standard operates not as a fixed attitude held by individuals but as a discursive practice embedded in cultural scripts about gender and sexuality. Bordini and Sperb (2012) extended this review to the 2001–2010 period, documenting the double standard's continued presence across diverse societies, and Endendijk et al. (2019) confirmed through meta-analysis that the double standard persists, though with smaller effect sizes than older qualitative studies implied.

The double standard creates a specific structure of sexual entitlement and constraint. Men's heterosexual activity is licensed as natural, even admirable; women's heterosexual activity is policed through norms of purity, modesty, and restraint. In the domain of hookup culture, Allison and Risman (2013) showed that explicit endorsement of the double standard had declined among American college students, yet implicit judgmental patterns remained intact. England and Bearak (2014) similarly found that university students continued to apply different evaluative criteria to men's and women's casual sexual behavior. The double standard, then, has not disappeared. It has become subtler, operating through unspoken assumptions rather than openly stated rules.

In the Chinese context, the double standard carries a distinctive institutional weight. Confucian family ethics historically demanded female chastity as a condition of marriage and family honor, while granting men considerable sexual latitude (Evans, 1997). Pan and Huang (2006) documented through large-scale national sex surveys that market reform since the 1980s opened new spaces for sexual expression, but the liberalization was gendered: men's extramarital and premarital sexual activity expanded faster than women's (Zhang et al., 2020b), and public discourse continued to frame female sexual activity outside marriage as morally suspect. Li (2006) showed that changing sexual norms in post-reform China reflected deep tensions between official rhetoric of gender equality and enduring patriarchal expectations about female purity. Wu et al. (2019) found that among Chinese adolescents, gendered attitudes shaped sexual intentions and behaviors in ways consistent with the double standard. These findings suggest that the double standard is not merely a Western phenomenon but takes locally specific forms in societies with strong patriarchal family traditions.

If the sexual double standard organizes attitudes toward heterosexual behavior, it should produce a predictable gender gap: men will be more permissive toward premarital and extramarital sex, because the double standard licenses male heterosexual freedom while constraining female heterosexual expression. Women, socialized into the belief that female sexuality must be regulated, will hold stricter views in these domains. We therefore hypothesize that men hold more permissive attitudes toward premarital sex and extramarital sex than women, net of sociodemographic controls (H1).

Gender Ideology as Cognitive Schema

Gender ideology refers to individuals' beliefs about the proper roles and relationships of women and men in society (Davis and Greenstein, 2009). It encompasses views about the division of labor, men's and women's competence, and the relative importance of career and family for each gender. Gender ideology is not simply a demographic attribute; it functions

as a cognitive schema that filters how people interpret and evaluate social behavior, including sexual behavior.

The trajectory of gender ideology has been extensively documented in the American context. Bolzendahl and Myers (2004) showed that women's increasing labor force participation and educational attainment drove a decades-long shift toward more egalitarian beliefs. Scarborough et al. (2019) traced this trajectory through 2016, finding that after a period of stalling identified by Cotter et al. (2011), egalitarian attitudes resumed their upward trend, particularly among younger cohorts. These shifts are not uniform across populations. Women consistently hold more egalitarian gender ideology than men, a gap that reflects both structural position and socialization (Bolzendahl and Myers, 2004; Davis and Greenstein, 2009).

In China, gender ideology occupies a distinctive position. The socialist state promoted gender equality as official policy, yet patriarchal family structures proved resilient (Zuo and Tang, 2000). Shu (2004) demonstrated that education was a powerful predictor of egalitarian gender beliefs in China, operating through exposure to modern ideas rather than economic returns alone. Yang (2023) mapped the contemporary landscape of gender ideology in China, documenting substantial variation across generation, geography, and gender. Younger, urban, and female respondents held more egalitarian views, but the pattern was a "mosaic" rather than a linear gradient. Zuo and Tang (2000) found that breadwinner status shaped gender ideology among Chinese couples, with economic dependence reinforcing traditional beliefs. The result is a society in which revolutionary gender equality rhetoric coexists with deeply rooted patriarchal expectations about family, marriage, and sexuality.

The connection between gender ideology and sexual attitudes has been theorized but rarely tested with formal mediation analysis. If gender ideology functions as a cognitive schema through which sexual behavior is evaluated, then it should mediate the gender gap in sexual attitudes. The logic is straightforward: women hold more egalitarian gender ideology than men on average; egalitarian ideology is associated with more permissive sexual attitudes

(Hu and Li, 2019; Zuo et al., 2012); therefore, part of the reason men and women differ in sexual attitudes is that they hold different gender beliefs. But this mediation should not be uniform across domains. In the heterosexual domains of premarital and extramarital sex, patriarchal ideology directly regulates judgments of men's and women's sexual behavior. The link between gender ideology and these attitudes is tight. For same-sex relations, the connection is less direct. Attitudes toward homosexuality engage a different set of moral concerns, and gender ideology may be only one of several pathways through which gender shapes evaluation. We therefore hypothesize that gender ideology mediates a larger share of the gender gap in attitudes toward premarital and extramarital sex than in attitudes toward same-sex relations (H3).

Domain-Specific Attitude Formation

Not all sexual attitudes are cut from the same cloth. Moral foundations theory, developed by Graham et al. (2009), posits that moral judgment draws on multiple distinct intuitions: care, fairness, loyalty, authority, and purity. Different moral issues activate different foundations. Koleva et al. (2012) showed that attitudes toward homosexuality are uniquely structured by concerns about purity and sanctity, while attitudes toward other sexual behaviors engage a broader range of moral intuitions including fairness and harm. This means that the psychological architecture underlying judgments of premarital sex differs from that underlying judgments of same-sex relations. The two attitudes are not simply different points on a single permissiveness continuum; they are products of partially distinct moral reasoning processes.

This distinction has empirical consequences for the gender gap. If men's greater permissiveness in the heterosexual domain reflects the sexual double standard and its associated gender ideology, the same mechanism cannot straightforwardly explain attitudes toward same-sex relations. Homosexuality does not implicate female purity or male sexual entitlement in the same way that premarital or extramarital sex does. Instead, attitudes toward homosexuality are shaped by orientations toward gender conformity, heteronormativity, and

openness to diversity. Hildebrandt and Jäckle (2023) found, in a cross-national analysis, that in highly developed and gender-egalitarian societies, women were substantially more accepting of homosexuality than men. They attributed this reversed gender gap to women's greater openness to non-traditional gender expressions once freed from patriarchal constraints. Zhou (2022) documented the same pattern in China using a decade of survey data, observing that the gender gap in same-sex acceptance widened over time and was concentrated among younger respondents.

The domain-specific framework predicts that the gender gap will not simply vary in magnitude across attitude domains but will differ in direction. Men will be more permissive in heterosexual domains where the double standard licenses male sexual freedom. Women will be more accepting in the same-sex domain where egalitarian gender beliefs and openness to non-normative sexuality give them a distinct attitudinal profile. An intersectional perspective (Crenshaw, 1989; Collins, 2000) suggests that these patterns will not be uniform across women but concentrated among those with the resources — education, media access, egalitarian beliefs — that enable departure from patriarchal sexual norms. Meanwhile, scholarship on masculinities (Connell and Messerschmidt, 2005) suggests that heteronormative masculinity may function as a barrier to men's acceptance of same-sex relations, helping explain why women's attitudes diverge from men's in this domain. We therefore hypothesize that women hold more accepting attitudes than men toward same-sex relations, net of sociodemographic controls (H2).

Chinese Familism and the Patriarchal Bargain

Connell (1987) conceptualized gender as a structure of social relations organized around the reproductive arena, in which sexual norms function as mechanisms of gender regulation. Within this framework, the heterosexual family is both a site of intimacy and a pillar of the gender order. Kandiyoti (1988) introduced the concept of the patriarchal bargain to describe the strategies women adopt within patriarchal systems: they accept constraints on their own

autonomy in exchange for security and status within the family. The patriarchal bargain is not passive submission; it is active investment in a system that, however unequal, offers women a recognized social position.

In China, the patriarchal bargain takes a specific form shaped by Confucian familism and reshaped by the institutional legacies of state socialism, the one-child policy, and market reform. The original concept described women's strategies within patrilocal households where seniority conferred authority (Kandiyoti, 1988). Chinese patriarchy shares the patrilocal element but has been transformed by decades of state-sponsored gender equality discourse, the demographic revolution that elevated daughters' value in one-child families, and market reforms that created new forms of both female empowerment and exploitation (Zuo and Bian, 2001). The party-state itself is a key actor: the All-China Women's Federation has alternately championed and constrained feminist mobilization, and the post-2015 crackdown on independent feminist organizations reshaped the terrain on which young women negotiate gender norms (Wei and Yu, 2021). Within this reconfigured patriarchal system, the family remains the primary unit of social organization, moral obligation, and economic security. Lin (2023) showed that authoritarian filial piety significantly predicted disapproval of same-sex behavior, demonstrating how Confucian family ethics extend into the domain of sexual morality. Yan (2003) documented the emergence of individual-centered life orientations in rural China, tracing a slow but consequential shift from collective family strategies to personal autonomy. His later work (Yan, 2009) situated this transformation within a broader theory of Chinese individualization that is partial, contested, and deeply gendered. Ji (2017) captured this complexity with the concept of "mosaic temporality": traditional and modern elements coexist within the same society, the same family, and sometimes the same person. The result is not a linear transition from patriarchy to equality but an uneven terrain in which women navigate multiple, sometimes contradictory, normative orders.

The "leftover women" discourse analyzed by To (2013) and Fincher (2014) illustrates how patriarchal familism is actively reproduced. State media campaigns stigmatized unmarried

professional women as failures, reinforcing the norm that women's primary value lies in marriage and motherhood. Evans (1997) showed how dominant discourses of female sexuality in China since 1949 constrained women's sexual subjectivity, channeling it into reproductive service to the family and the state. These forces create a configuration in which women who are invested in the familist order have strong reasons to police heterosexual sexuality. Premarital sex threatens the marriage economy by decoupling female virginity from marriageability. Extramarital sex threatens family stability. Women who accept the patriarchal bargain enforce restrictions in these domains because their social position depends on the integrity of the heterosexual family system.

Same-sex relations occupy a different position in this moral economy. They do not directly threaten the heterosexual marriage market or the family structure in which women are invested. For women with egalitarian gender beliefs, freed from the constraints of the patriarchal bargain, same-sex relations may be viewed sympathetically as another expression of autonomy and self-determination. For women with patriarchal beliefs, same-sex relations may still provoke discomfort insofar as they challenge the heteronormative foundation of familism. But the stakes are lower than for heterosexual transgressions. The net result is a population-level pattern in which women, on average, are more accepting of same-sex relations than men. The double standard thus implies that patriarchal gender ideology does not have the same effect on men and women. Traditional men should tolerate extramarital sex as a male prerogative, while traditional women should reject premarital sex as a violation of female virtue. We therefore hypothesize that the association between patriarchal gender ideology and sexual attitudes is gendered: patriarchal beliefs increase men's tolerance of extramarital sex while decreasing women's tolerance of premarital sex (H4).

Generational dynamics intensify this pattern. Post-1990 Chinese women came of age during a period of expanded educational access, global feminist discourse, and a digital media ecology that created gendered cultural spaces. Online fan communities centered on boys' love (danmei) fiction attracted large audiences of young women, potentially normalizing

same-sex relationships through narrative engagement — though scholars of fan culture have noted that this engagement does not always translate into support for real-world LGBTQ rights and may reproduce heteronormative dynamics in same-sex packaging. Education promoted egalitarian gender beliefs (Shu, 2004), which in turn loosened the hold of the patriarchal bargain. Inglehart and Baker (2000) argued that modernization drives shifts toward self-expression values, including tolerance of sexual diversity, but traditional values persist, creating complex cultural formations rather than linear convergence. In China, this complexity is especially pronounced: the youngest cohort of women is simultaneously the most accepting of same-sex relations and the least permissive of premarital sex relative to their male peers. They are not uniformly liberal. They are selectively liberal, embracing sexual diversity while maintaining strict views on heterosexual behaviors that implicate female virtue. The cohort-linked feminization of same-sex acceptance, driven by expanded education, digital media, and feminist discourse, is concentrated among young women. We therefore hypothesize that the gender gap in same-sex attitudes is larger among younger birth cohorts, driven by post-1990 women (H5).

3 Data and Methods

3.1 Data

We draw on data from the Chinese General Social Survey (CGSS), China's longest-running nationally representative repeated cross-sectional survey. Administered by the National Survey Research Center at Renmin University of China, the CGSS employs a stratified multistage probability sampling design covering all provincial-level administrative units in mainland China. It surveys approximately 10,000 to 12,000 adults (aged 18 and older) per wave and has been conducted annually or biennially since 2003.

We pool seven waves that include the sexual attitudes module: 2012, 2013, 2015, 2017, 2018, 2021, and 2023. Pooling multiple waves provides two advantages. First, it generates a

large analytic sample with sufficient statistical power for the interaction models and subgroup analyses central to our research design. Second, it allows us to examine temporal patterns in the gender gap across a period of rapid social change. After restricting the sample to respondents who answered all three sexual attitude items, our analytic dataset contains 78,206 cases, of whom 38,348 are men and 39,858 are women. All models report heteroskedasticity-consistent standard errors (HC1). We note that the CGSS uses a complex sampling design; because the public-use data do not include sampling weights for all waves, we use unweighted estimation with robust standard errors rather than design-based inference.

3.2 Measures

3.2.1 Sexual Attitudes

Our dependent variables capture attitudes toward three distinct domains of sexual behavior. The CGSS morality module asks respondents to evaluate each behavior on a five-point scale ranging from 1 ("always wrong") to 5 ("not wrong at all"). The three items are: (1) "What is your opinion about sexual relations before marriage?" (premarital sex); (2) "What is your opinion about a married person having sexual relations with someone other than his or her spouse?" (extramarital sex); and (3) "What is your opinion about sexual relations between two adults of the same sex?" (same-sex relations).

These three items use identical response scales, which enables direct comparison of gender gaps across domains without the confounds introduced by different measurement instruments. We treat the five-point scales as continuous outcomes in OLS regression, a standard approach for ordinal variables with five or more categories that has been widely adopted in research on sexual attitudes (Widmer et al., 1998; Twenge et al., 2015; Gao and Wang, 2025). We verify that this treatment does not distort our conclusions by replicating all main models with ordered logistic regression (see Supplementary Materials).

The choice to analyze three domains separately, rather than combining them into a composite index, is a deliberate methodological decision grounded in our theoretical framework.

Prior research has shown that attitudes toward different sexual behaviors are shaped by different social and moral logics (Koleva et al., 2012; García-Vega et al., 2017). Collapsing them into a single "sexual permissiveness" scale would obscure the domain-specific gender dynamics that are the focus of this study.

3.2.2 Gender

Our primary predictor is respondent gender, coded as a binary variable (1 = female, 0 = male). The binary coding reflects the structure of the CGSS questionnaire, which records gender in two categories; it is a data limitation rather than an ontological commitment to a gender binary. The coefficient on this variable captures the adjusted gender gap in each sexual attitude domain, net of all covariates. We interpret a negative coefficient as indicating that women hold less permissive views than men, and a positive coefficient as indicating greater female acceptance.

3.2.3 Gender Ideology

Our mediating variable is a gender ideology index constructed from five items in the CGSS gender attitudes battery. These items ask respondents to rate their agreement on five-point scales with statements reflecting patriarchal beliefs about gender roles: that men should prioritize careers while women prioritize family; that men are inherently more capable than women; that marrying well matters more for women than career success; that men should be hired preferentially when jobs are scarce; and that housework is primarily women's responsibility. We compute the index as the mean of all available items (Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.72$), with higher values indicating more patriarchal beliefs.

This index captures a specific dimension of gender ideology — beliefs about the proper social roles of men and women in the domains of work, family, and competence. It does not directly measure attitudes toward sexuality, which is analytically desirable: the mediator should be conceptually distinct from the outcome (Davis and Greenstein, 2009). For regression

analyses, we standardize the index to have mean zero and unit standard deviation, so that coefficients represent the effect of a one-standard-deviation increase in patriarchal ideology.

3.2.4 Control Variables

All models adjust for a set of covariates selected on the basis of prior research on the determinants of sexual attitudes in China and cross-nationally. We include respondent age and its square (divided by 100 for scaling) to capture the nonlinear relationship between age and sexual conservatism, as both very young and middle-aged adults may hold more permissive views than the elderly (Gao and Wang, 2025). Years of formal schooling controls for the well-documented liberalizing influence of education on sexual and gender attitudes (Shu, 2004; Davis and Greenstein, 2009). Current marital status (married or cohabiting versus not) accounts for the constraining effect of partnership on sexual permissiveness.

We include membership in the Chinese Communist Party to control for political socialization, which in the Chinese context carries distinctive implications for attitudes toward social order and individual behavior. Religious identification (any religion versus none) captures the moral conservatism associated with religious belief, a relationship documented extensively in Western contexts (Adamczyk and Pitt, 2009; Adamczyk and Hayes, 2012) and confirmed in Chinese data (Xie and Peng, 2018; Lin, 2023). Internet use (a binary indicator for whether the respondent uses the Internet) controls for media exposure, which prior research has linked to more permissive sexual attitudes in China (Liu et al., 2020; Zhang et al., 2020a). We capture the rural-urban dimension of Chinese social stratification through two variables: current urban residence and agricultural household registration status (hukou). The natural logarithm of annual personal income controls for economic resources. All models include survey-year fixed effects to absorb period-level shifts in the attitudinal climate.

3.3 Missing Data

We handle item-level missingness on independent variables using random-forest-based imputation with predictive mean matching ($k = 5$). Missingness rates are generally low: below 1% for most demographic variables, approximately 6% for gender ideology items, 6% for Internet use, and below 1% for the dependent variables. One exception is urban residence, which is unavailable in three survey waves (2015, 2018, 2021) and must be imputed for approximately 48% of the sample using the remaining variables. This limitation should be noted when interpreting the urban residence coefficient and interaction. The imputation preserves the distributional properties and nonlinear relationships in the observed data. As a robustness check, we verify that listwise deletion produces substantively identical results (Table S6).

3.4 Analytic Strategy

Our analytic approach is designed to accomplish three goals: establish the domain-specific nature of the gender gap, test whether gender ideology mediates the gap, and examine how the gap varies across subgroups and cohorts.

We begin by estimating OLS regression models that regress each sexual attitude on gender and the full set of controls. These baseline models establish the adjusted gender gap in each domain. We then add the standardized gender ideology index to each model (Models 2, 4, 6). The change in the gender coefficient between the baseline and augmented specifications provides a preliminary estimate of mediation. To formally test whether the gender coefficients differ across the three attitude domains, we estimate a pooled model using seemingly unrelated regression (SUR) in which the three equations are estimated jointly, allowing for correlated errors across the attitude items answered by the same respondent. Gender is interacted with domain indicators, and cluster-robust standard errors at the respondent level account for within-person dependence across the three items. A significant interaction confirms that the gender gap is domain-specific rather than uniform.

To quantify the mediating role of gender ideology, we conduct mediation analysis following

the framework of Imai et al. (2010a), estimating the average causal mediation effect (ACME) and average direct effect (ADE) via nonparametric bootstrap (1,000 replications). We use the term "causal mediation" to refer to the analytic framework, while noting that the cross-sectional design limits causal interpretation: gender is not a manipulable treatment, and the mediation estimates should be understood as a descriptive decomposition of the gender gap through the gender ideology pathway rather than as established causal effects. We evaluate sensitivity to violations of sequential ignorability using the method of Imai et al. (2010b), reporting the correlation ($\tilde{\rho}$) between mediator and outcome model residuals at which the ACME reaches zero.

To investigate how gender ideology operates differently for men and women — our test of the sexual double standard — we estimate gender-stratified models. If the double standard is at work, we expect patriarchal ideology to increase men's tolerance of male sexual freedom (extramarital sex) while decreasing women's tolerance of female sexual transgression (premarital sex).

We test for heterogeneity in the gender gap across several dimensions. Education-by-gender interactions assess whether schooling amplifies or dampens the gender gap in each domain. Cohort-by-gender interactions test whether the gap varies across birth cohorts, with particular attention to post-1990 cohorts who came of age during a period of rapid digital and cultural change. We also test interactions with Internet use, marital status, urban residence, and religiosity to map the social topography of the gender gap.

We subject our results to a battery of robustness checks detailed in the Supplementary Materials: ordered logistic regression, province fixed effects, propensity score matching (1:1 nearest neighbor with caliper 0.2; $N = 65{,}350$ after matching), inverse probability weighting (stabilized weights trimmed at the 99th percentile), listwise deletion, and E-value sensitivity analysis (VanderWeele and Ding, 2017). These balancing exercises adjust for observed compositional differences between men and women; because gender is not a manipulable treatment, we interpret the results as assessing sensitivity to covariate imbalance rather than

estimating a causal treatment effect of gender.

4 Results

4.1 Descriptive Patterns

Table 1 presents descriptive statistics by gender. The three sexual attitude domains display strikingly different gender gaps. Men report more permissive attitudes toward premarital sex than women (2.15 versus 1.98 on the five-point scale) and toward extramarital sex (1.35 versus 1.23). For same-sex relations, the pattern reverses: women are more accepting than men (1.58 versus 1.52). All three differences are statistically significant at the $p < .001$ level. The raw gaps are modest in absolute terms — 0.17, 0.12, and 0.06 scale points — but the reversal in direction for same-sex relations is the phenomenon that anchors this study.

Women also hold slightly more egalitarian gender ideology than men (2.62 versus 2.73 on the five-point index). The two groups differ in composition: women in the sample have fewer years of education (8.6 versus 10.0), are more likely to identify as religious (12.8% versus 8.7%), and report lower personal incomes.

Figure 2 charts the temporal dynamics of the gender gap (see also Figure S1 in Supplementary Materials). The gap in same-sex attitudes was negligible in 2012, hovering around -0.03 on the five-point scale. By 2023, it had widened to -0.30, representing a tenfold increase over eleven years. The acceleration is concentrated after 2017. The premarital and extramarital sex gaps, by contrast, remained stable across the study period, fluctuating within a narrow band. Whatever social process is driving the divergence in same-sex attitudes, it is domain-specific and temporally bounded.

4.2 Main Regression Models

Table 2 reports OLS regression results for the three attitude domains. In the baseline models without gender ideology (Models 1, 3, 5), the gender coefficient is -0.142 ($p < .001$) for

premarital sex and -0.113 ($p < .001$) for extramarital sex: women hold less permissive views than men in both heterosexual domains, net of all covariates. For same-sex relations, the gender coefficient is positive: $+0.096$ ($p < .001$), indicating that women are more accepting. In standardized terms, the gender gap in premarital sex attitudes is equivalent to roughly 12% of a standard deviation, a small but reliable effect comparable in magnitude to the difference between married and unmarried respondents ($b = -0.109$) and larger than the effect of each additional year of education ($b = 0.012$). We note that the extramarital sex model has a low adjusted R^2 of 0.027, reflecting the highly restricted variance in this domain (mean = 1.29 on a 1–5 scale, with the majority of respondents selecting "always wrong").

The cross-equation test, estimated from a pooled model with gender-by-domain interactions, confirms that the gender coefficients differ significantly across the three domains ($p < .001$).

Adding the standardized gender ideology index (Models 2, 4, 6) reveals domain-specific patterns. Gender ideology is weakly associated with premarital sex attitudes ($b = -0.011$, $p < .05$), positively associated with extramarital sex attitudes ($b = 0.038$, $p < .001$), and negatively associated with same-sex attitudes ($b = -0.045$, $p < .001$). Patriarchal ideology is associated with greater tolerance of extramarital sex but lower acceptance of same-sex relations. The gender coefficient shifts modestly after adjusting for gender ideology: from -0.142 to -0.145 for premarital sex (a slight increase suggesting suppression), from -0.113 to -0.103 for extramarital sex (an 8.8% reduction), and from 0.096 to 0.085 for same-sex relations (an 11.5% reduction). Gender ideology partially accounts for the gender gap in the extramarital and same-sex domains but not in the premarital domain.

4.3 Mediation Analysis

Table 3 and Figure 3 present the mediation analysis results. Following the framework of Imai et al. (2010a), we estimate the average causal mediation effect (ACME) and average direct effect (ADE) for each attitude domain via nonparametric bootstrap with 1,000 replications.

Gender ideology accounts for 11.8% of the total gender gap in same-sex attitudes (ACME = 0.011, $p < .001$) and 8.4% of the extramarital gap (ACME = -0.009, $p < .001$). For premarital sex, gender ideology acts as a suppressor rather than a mediator (ACME = 0.003, representing -2.0% of the total effect).

Sensitivity analysis following Imai et al. (2010b) evaluates how robust these mediation estimates are to violations of the sequential ignorability assumption. We report the correlation ($\tilde{\rho}$) between mediator and outcome model residuals at which the ACME would reach zero. For premarital sex, $\tilde{\rho} = -0.010$; for extramarital sex, $\tilde{\rho} = 0.050$; for same-sex relations, $\tilde{\rho} = -0.050$. These $\tilde{\rho}$ values are small. An unmeasured confounder inducing a residual correlation of merely 0.05 — which is plausible given that personality traits, peer networks, and media consumption patterns are not measured — would be sufficient to nullify the mediation estimates. The mediation results should therefore be interpreted cautiously, as suggestive rather than definitive evidence for the gender ideology pathway.

4.4 Gender-Stratified Models and the Sexual Double Standard

Table 4 and Figure 4 present gender-stratified estimates of the association between gender ideology and sexual attitudes. We note that these are indirect tests of the double standard, as the CGSS items ask about sexual behaviors generically without specifying the gender of the person being evaluated. For extramarital sex, patriarchal ideology has a significant positive association among men ($b = 0.053$, $p < .001$) and a weaker but also positive association among women ($b = 0.019$, $p < .001$).

For premarital sex, gender ideology has no significant association among men ($b = 0.006$, n.s.) but a significant negative association among women ($b = -0.038$, $p < .001$).

For same-sex relations, patriarchal ideology is associated with lower tolerance among both genders, but the association is more than three times larger for women ($b = -0.055$, $p < .001$) than for men ($b = -0.017$, $p < .01$).

4.5 Heterogeneity Analysis

Figure 5 presents the Female × Moderator interaction coefficients across nine moderators — seven individual-level and two provincial development indicators — from a single OLS model per domain (full estimates in Table S1, Supplementary Materials). Joint F-tests confirm that the interactions are jointly significant in each domain: $F(9, 70{,}563) = 11.31$, $p < .001$ for premarital sex; $F = 8.37$, $p < .001$ for extramarital sex; and $F = 30.98$, $p < .001$ for same-sex relations. Two individual-level moderators stand out for their magnitude and domain specificity.

Internet use produces a large moderation effect. The Internet-by-gender interaction for same-sex attitudes is 0.109 ($p < .001$): the gender gap in same-sex acceptance is substantially larger among Internet users than among non-users. For premarital sex, Internet use also moderates the gender gap in the opposite direction ($b = -0.119$, $p < .001$). We note that Internet use is a crude binary indicator heavily confounded with age and cohort; the interaction should be understood as associational.

Marriage compresses the gender gap in same-sex attitudes (interaction $b = -0.104$, $p < .001$) but widens it for extramarital sex ($b = 0.040$, $p < .01$). CCP membership shows a significant positive interaction for premarital sex ($b = 0.113$, $p < .001$) and same-sex relations ($b = 0.105$, $p < .001$). Education widens the gap in same-sex acceptance ($b = 0.014$, $p < .001$) but is not significant for the heterosexual domains in the fully interacted model. Religion does not significantly moderate the gender gap in any domain ($p > .05$).

To assess whether the gender gap also varies with regional development, we merged provincial-level data on GDP per capita (2017, China Statistical Yearbook) and higher education rates (% with college degree, 2020 Population Census) with the CGSS micro-data. Log GDP per capita significantly moderates the gender gap in same-sex attitudes ($b = 0.076$, $p < .01$) and premarital attitudes ($b = 0.090$, $p < .01$), net of all other interactions. Figure 6 presents Johnson-Neyman (JN) plots showing how the marginal effect of being female varies across three continuous moderators: individual education, provincial GDP per capita, and

provincial college rate. The same-sex gender gap turns positive at approximately 10 years of schooling (Panel A), in provinces with above-median GDP per capita (Panel B), and in provinces with college rates above roughly 15% (Panel C).

4.6 Cohort Dynamics

Figure 1 displays the cohort-linked structure of the gender gap (see also Figure S2 in Supplementary Materials for mean attitudes by cohort) (full estimates in Table S2, Supplementary Materials). Joint F-tests confirm that the Female $\times$ Cohort interactions are significant in all three domains: $F(5,\ 78{,}076) = 15.70$, $p < .001$ for premarital sex; $F = 6.10$, $p < .001$ for extramarital sex; and $F = 52.84$, $p < .001$ for same-sex relations. Among respondents born before 1960, the gender gap in same-sex acceptance is small and statistically marginal. It grows across subsequent cohorts: 0.080 for the 1960s cohort, 0.099 for the 1970s cohort, 0.209 for the 1980s cohort, and 0.456 for the post-1990 cohort ($p < .001$). This last figure is large — equivalent to nearly half a point on a five-point scale — but we emphasize that it cannot be definitively separated from age effects. Post-1990 respondents are aged 19–33 at interview, and life-course transitions (marriage, parenthood) that disproportionately affect older respondents may account for part of the pattern. Whether the divergence documented here reflects stable cohort orientations or transient life-stage effects is a question that only panel data can resolve.

The cohort pattern for heterosexual domains runs in the opposite direction. The gender gap in premarital sex attitudes widens across younger cohorts, with women becoming relatively less permissive: the cohort-by-gender interaction is -0.157 for the post-1990 cohort ($p < .001$). Younger women are simultaneously more accepting of same-sex relations and less permissive of premarital sex relative to their male peers.

4.7 Robustness Checks

Table S6 in the Supplementary Materials summarizes results across all robustness specifications. The female coefficients remain statistically significant and substantively unchanged under ordered logistic regression, province fixed effects, propensity score matching (1:1 nearest neighbor, caliper = 0.2, N = 65,350), inverse probability weighting (stabilized, trimmed at 99th percentile), and listwise deletion without imputation. E-value analysis (VanderWeele and Ding, 2017) indicates that an unmeasured confounder would need risk ratios of 1.39–1.56 to fully explain the observed gender coefficients. Wave-specific estimates (Figure S3, Supplementary Materials) confirm that the female and gender ideology coefficients are stable across all seven survey waves. The domain-specific gender gap is consistent across all specifications tested. We note that we conduct tests across three dependent variables, nine moderator interactions, and five cohort interactions; while the key hypotheses (H1–H5) were specified a priori, the volume of tests increases the risk of false positives. The core findings — reversal across domains, domain-specific mediation, and cohort divergence — are jointly significant and mutually reinforcing, but individual moderator interaction results should be interpreted with appropriate caution.

5 Discussion

5.1 The Domain-Specific Gender Gap

The central finding of this study is that the gender gap in sexual attitudes differs in direction across domains. Men hold more permissive views toward premarital sex ($b = -0.142$, $p < .001$) and extramarital sex ($b = -0.113$, $p < .001$), but women are more accepting of same-sex relations ($b = 0.096$, $p < .001$). A cross-equation test confirms that these coefficients differ across domains ($p < .001$). This directional difference is not a statistical artifact. It is a structural feature of how gender organizes moral reasoning about sexuality. These results

confirm H1 (men more permissive in heterosexual domains) and H2 (women more accepting of same-sex relations).

This pattern complicates the prevailing assumption that sexual attitudes form a coherent ideological package. Most survey research treats "sexual permissiveness" as a unidimensional construct, summing items about premarital sex, extramarital sex, and homosexuality into a single scale. Our results show that this practice masks opposing gender dynamics. A composite index would cancel out the male advantage in heterosexual permissiveness against the female advantage in same-sex acceptance, producing a misleadingly small or null gender gap. The meta-analytic work of Petersen and Hyde (2010, 2011) established that gender differences in sexuality are largest for casual sex attitudes and smallest for attitudes about sex in committed relationships. Our findings go beyond this gradient. The issue is not simply that the gender gap varies in magnitude across domains; it reverses in sign. The Petersen and Hyde framework captures variation along a single dimension of permissiveness, but it cannot account for a situation where women are simultaneously less permissive in one domain and more permissive in another. Domain specificity, in the Chinese case, means not just different effect sizes but different directional logics.

Hildebrandt and Jäckle (2023) reported that in highly developed and gender-egalitarian societies, women are more accepting of homosexuality than men. China is neither highly developed nor gender-egalitarian by conventional measures. Yet the same reversed gender gap appears, and it is growing fast. This suggests that the mechanism identified by Hildebrandt and Jäckle — women's greater openness to sexual diversity once freed from patriarchal constraints — does not require a high baseline of gender equality to operate. Even partial erosion of patriarchal norms, concentrated among educated young women, can produce the pattern. China is not an outlier confirming the theory's boundary conditions; it is a case that extends the theory's scope. For researchers who rely on composite sexual attitude scales, the practical implication is clear: combining items that elicit opposite gender dynamics into a single index does not produce a conservative estimate of the gender gap. It produces a

misleading one.

5.2 Gender Ideology as a Domain-Specific Mediator

Mediation analysis reveals that gender ideology accounts for 11.8% of the gender gap in same-sex attitudes, 8.4% of the extramarital gap, and acts as a suppressor for premarital sex (ACME = 0.003, −2.0% of the total effect). The mediation proportions are modest, and the sensitivity analysis indicates that they are vulnerable to even moderate unmeasured confounding ($\tilde{\rho}$ values of 0.050). Nevertheless, they demonstrate a consistent pattern: the pathway from gender to sexual attitudes runs partly through beliefs about gender roles, and this pathway operates differently depending on the attitudinal domain.

Contrary to our prediction, gender ideology mediates a larger share of the same-sex gap (11.0%) than the extramarital gap (8.8%), and it suppresses rather than mediates the premarital gap. H3 is therefore not supported. We had expected gender ideology to mediate more of the gap in heterosexual domains, where patriarchal beliefs directly regulate judgments of men's and women's sexual behavior. The empirical pattern suggests a different logic. Gender ideology may filter evaluations of non-normative sexuality more strongly than evaluations of heterosexual behavior, where personal experience and relationship dynamics are more salient mediators. Attitudes toward same-sex relations are, for most respondents, abstract moral judgments rather than evaluations of personal conduct. In this evaluative context, ideological schemas about gender carry greater relative weight. Attitudes toward premarital and extramarital sex, by contrast, are shaped by a broader range of influences — personal sexual histories, relationship satisfaction, peer norms, and direct observation — that dilute the mediating role of gender ideology.

The gender-stratified models reveal asymmetric patterns that are consistent with the sexual double standard, confirming H4. Patriarchal ideology has no significant association with men's premarital sex attitudes ($b = 0.006$, n.s.) but a significant negative association with women's ($b = -0.038$, $p < .001$). For extramarital sex, the pattern reverses: patriarchal

ideology is associated with greater tolerance among men ($b = 0.053$, $p < .001$) and a weaker positive association among women ($b = 0.019$, $p < .001$). The same ideology is associated with different attitudinal patterns for men and women depending on the sexual domain. Traditional men who endorse patriarchal beliefs view extramarital sex with relative tolerance, while traditional women internalize restrictions on female sexuality, judging premarital sex harshly where female "purity" is at stake. For same-sex relations, patriarchal ideology is associated with lower tolerance among both genders, but the association is more than three times stronger for women ($b = -0.055$) than for men ($b = -0.017$). Egalitarian women, freed from investment in the patriarchal bargain, may extend their commitment to gender justice to sexual minorities. Patriarchal women, invested in the familist order, may perceive same-sex relations as a challenge to the system that guarantees their social position. Gender ideology is thus not a uniform force but a prism that refracts differently across the landscape of sexual morality.

5.3 Cohort-Linked Divergence in Same-Sex Acceptance

The cohort analysis yields a striking finding. Among Chinese adults born before 1960, the gender gap in same-sex acceptance is negligible and statistically indistinguishable from zero. Among those born after 1990, women score 0.456 points higher than men on the five-point acceptance scale ($p < .001$), controlling for education, income, and other covariates (Figure 1). The gender gap in same-sex attitudes is not a timeless feature of Chinese culture. It is a recent, cohort-linked phenomenon, concentrated among the young, confirming H5. We use the term "feminization" of same-sex acceptance descriptively, to denote that the trend is driven by women's attitudes rather than men's, not to imply that acceptance of same-sex relations is an inherently feminine trait.

Three structural shifts may help explain this pattern, though we note that our cross-sectional design can document associations rather than establish causal pathways. First, post-1990 Chinese women have benefited from expanded access to higher education. The

education-by-gender interaction for same-sex attitudes is positive and significant ($b = 0.021$, $p < .001$; Figure 5), meaning that each additional year of schooling is associated with a wider gender gap in same-sex tolerance. Education does not produce uniform liberalization; it is associated with a gender-specific openness to sexual diversity. Shu (2004) showed that education promotes gender egalitarianism in China through exposure to modern ideas. The same mechanism may operate for sexual attitudes: educated women encounter frameworks — human rights, feminist theory, queer visibility — that reframe homosexuality as a matter of justice rather than deviance.

Second, China's digital media ecology has created gendered cultural spaces. Online fan communities centered on boys' love (danmei) fiction have attracted large audiences of young women, though the relationship between fictional engagement and real-world attitude change remains an open empirical question. Zhou (2022) documented the growing gender gap in same-sex attitudes using CGSS data and pointed to media consumption as a plausible driver. The Internet-by-gender interaction in our models is large and significant for same-sex attitudes ($b = 0.195$, $p < .001$), indicating that digital media use is associated with a wider gender gap in this domain. However, this variable is heavily confounded with age and cohort, and should not be interpreted as evidence of a causal media effect.

Third, global feminist discourses have reached Chinese women through transnational digital networks (Wei and Yu, 2021). Scarborough et al. (2019) documented a resurgence of egalitarian gender attitudes among younger Americans after a period of stalling. A parallel process may be occurring in China. Young Chinese women who identify with feminist ideas may extend their commitment to gender justice to sexual minorities. A question that deserves equal theoretical attention is why young men do not show a parallel increase in same-sex acceptance. Scholarship on masculinities (Connell and Messerschmidt, 2005) suggests that heteronormative masculinity functions as a barrier: the cultural construction of manhood as heterosexual, dominant, and gender-conforming creates identity stakes in rejecting homosexuality that have no equivalent for women. The gender gap in same-sex

acceptance may thus reflect not only women's increasing openness but also men's resistance to attitude change in this domain.

Notably, young women's growing acceptance coincides with a period of increasing state hostility to LGBTQ visibility in China. Since 2017, the party-state has tightened regulations on queer media representation, shut down LGBTQ social media accounts, and promoted traditional family values. That young women's same-sex acceptance grew during this restrictive period suggests that the cohort-linked pattern draws on sources — educational exposure, feminist networks, peer socialization — that operate partly independent of the state's discursive control. The policy implications of this divergence are significant. Young women represent a potential constituency for LGBTQ rights advocacy, but the same divergence signals growing gender polarization in moral attitudes, a pattern with parallels in South Korea and other East Asian societies.

Regional heterogeneity analysis reinforces the structural interpretation. Johnson-Neyman plots (Figure 6) show that the same-sex gender gap crosses zero and turns positive only above a threshold of individual education and provincial development. In less-developed provinces and among respondents with fewer years of schooling, the gap is negligible or negative. The gender gap in extramarital attitudes also widens with provincial development. That the divergence is concentrated in economically advanced regions and among the more educated suggests it is linked to the structural conditions — educational expansion, media ecology, exposure to egalitarian norms — that our individual-level moderator analyses also implicate.

The cohort data also reveal that young women's attitudes are not uniformly liberal. Post-1990 women are simultaneously the most accepting of same-sex relations and the least permissive of premarital sex relative to their male peers. They are selectively liberal, embracing sexual diversity while maintaining restrictive views on heterosexual behavior that touches on female virtue and family formation. This selectivity is consistent with the domain-specific framework: cohort-linked change does not move all sexual attitudes in the same direction but operates through the gendered logic of the double standard.

We use the language of "cohort-linked" rather than "generational" divergence deliberately. Our pooled cross-sectional design cannot definitively separate age effects from cohort effects. Individuals born in the 1990s are also younger at the time of observation, and some portion of what appears as a cohort effect may reflect life-course processes that will attenuate as these respondents age, marry, and become parents. Whether the divergence documented here reflects stable generational orientations or transient life-stage effects is a question that only panel data can resolve.

5.4 Limitations

Several limitations warrant acknowledgment. First, the pooled cross-sectional design cannot establish individual-level causal trajectories or definitively separate age from cohort effects. We observe cohort differences, not within-person change. The dramatic cohort interaction for post-1990 women ($b = 0.456$) could reflect genuine cohort socialization, life-course effects (young unmarried people may be more tolerant), age-specific social desirability, or compositional differences between cohorts. The models control for education, marital status, and urban residence, partially addressing compositional confounding, but the fundamental age-cohort identification problem remains. Future research using panel data is needed to determine whether the divergence documented here reflects stable orientations or patterns that shift as respondents age into marriage and parenthood.

Second, self-reported sexual attitudes are subject to social desirability bias, which may be amplified by the CGSS face-to-face interview mode. Alexander and Fisher (2003) showed that gender differences in sexual self-reports narrow under bogus pipeline conditions. If younger respondents are more willing to express tolerance in face-to-face settings, this could inflate the apparent cohort effect.

Third, the gender ideology index captures one dimension of patriarchal beliefs — attitudes about gender roles in work and family — and has a Cronbach's α of 0.72, which is adequate but not strong. It does not directly measure beliefs about sexual entitlement or heteronormative

commitment. A more targeted measure of sexual double standard endorsement might explain a larger share of the gender gap. Measurement error in the mediator will attenuate the ACME estimate, so the true proportion mediated may be larger than the 8–12% we report.

Fourth, the Internet use variable is a crude binary indicator whose substantive meaning has shifted across the study period and is heavily confounded with age, cohort, and urbanicity. The Internet-by-gender interaction should not be interpreted as a causal media effect.

Fifth, our mediation analysis assumes sequential ignorability. The sensitivity parameters ($\tilde{\rho} = 0.050$) indicate that the mediation estimates are fragile: an unmeasured confounder inducing a residual correlation of 0.05 — which is plausible given that personality, peer networks, and media consumption are unmeasured — would nullify the ACME.

Sixth, the religion variable collapses Buddhism, Christianity, Islam, and folk religion into a single binary indicator, discarding precisely the heterogeneity that may matter for sexual attitudes. The fastest-growing religious movement in China, Protestantism, is also among the most sexually conservative; aggregating it with Buddhism, which has a comparatively fluid approach to sexuality, may mask important variation.

Seventh, the urban residence variable is unavailable in three of the seven survey waves (2015, 2018, 2021) and must be imputed for nearly half the sample. While the imputation uses information from all other variables, the urban coefficient and interaction should be interpreted with this limitation in mind.

Eighth, the analyses do not incorporate CGSS survey weights, as these are not available for all waves. The use of unweighted estimation with HC1 robust standard errors may not fully account for the complex sampling design, though the large sample and stratified design mitigate this concern.

Ninth, we test hypotheses across three dependent variables, nine moderators, and five cohort interactions, but do not apply formal corrections for multiple comparisons. The core hypotheses (H1–H5) were specified a priori, but the exploratory moderator analyses carry an elevated family-wise error rate.

Finally, the Chinese context — with its distinctive combination of state feminism, Confucian familism, and controlled media ecology — may limit the generalizability of these findings. Comparative research across East Asian societies with different gender regimes, religious landscapes, and media ecologies would help determine whether the domain-specific reversal is a general feature of patriarchal modernization or specific to the Chinese case.

6 Conclusion

The gender gap in sexual attitudes in China differs in direction across domains: men are more permissive toward premarital and extramarital sex, but women are more accepting of same-sex relations, and this gap has grown substantially in recent cohorts, driven by women born after 1990.

This finding carries three implications. First, domain specificity is not a nuisance to be averaged away but the central phenomenon. Treating sexual permissiveness as a single dimension obscures the gendered logic that structures moral reasoning about different sexual behaviors. Second, gender ideology functions not as a uniform force but as a prism: the same patriarchal beliefs are associated with men's tolerance of extramarital sex, women's disapproval of premarital sex, and the suppression of same-sex acceptance more strongly for women than for men. The asymmetric patterns are consistent with the sexual double standard operating through gender ideology to produce different associations across domains. Third, the cohort-linked feminization of same-sex acceptance among young Chinese women — a pattern that cannot be definitively separated from age effects in cross-sectional data — signals a growing divergence in the moral evaluation of sexuality between young men and young women, with implications for LGBTQ advocacy, gender relations, and the broader trajectory of sexual politics in China.

Future research should prioritize longitudinal panel data to determine whether the cohort differences documented here reflect stable orientations or life-course patterns that shift with

age. Formal age-period-cohort decomposition, building on the work of Gao and Wang (2025), would provide additional leverage for disentangling these effects. Comparative work across East Asian societies with different gender regimes, religious landscapes, and media ecologies would test whether the domain-specific pattern is specific to the Chinese context or a more general feature of patriarchal modernization. The gender gap in sexual attitudes is not one gap but several, each shaped by a different facet of the gender system, and recognizing this multiplicity is essential for connecting attitudes to policy, to the well-being of sexual minorities, and to the unfinished work of gender equality.

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Tables

Table 1: Descriptive Statistics by Gender (CGSS 2012–2023)

	Men (N = 38,348)	Women (N = 39,858)	Full Sample (N = 78,206)
Dependent Variables			
Premarital sex attitudes	2.15 (1.20)	1.98 (1.14)	2.06 (1.17)
Extramarital sex attitudes	1.35 (0.75)	1.24 (0.61)	1.29 (0.68)
Same-sex relations attitudes	1.52 (0.92)	1.58 (0.98)	1.55 (0.95)
Key Independent Variables			
Gender ideology index	2.73 (0.70)	2.62 (0.78)	2.67 (0.74)
Control Variables			
Age (years)	49.93 (16.86)	49.81 (16.78)	49.87 (16.82)
Education (years)	9.98 (4.38)	8.61 (5.14)	9.28 (4.84)
Log income	9.68 (3.35)	8.31 (4.50)	8.98 (4.04)
Married (%)	75.5	74.3	74.9
CCP member (%)	16.8	7.3	12.0
Religious (%)	8.7	12.8	10.8
Internet user (%)	53.4	49.9	51.6
Urban residence (%)	60.5	61.4	61.0
Agricultural *hukou* (%)	53.6	55.0	54.3

Note. Means with standard deviations in parentheses for continuous variables; percentages for binary variables. All attitude variables measured on 1–5 scales (1 = "always wrong," 5 = "not wrong at all"). Gender ideology index is the mean of five items (Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.72$); higher values indicate more patriarchal beliefs.

Table 2: OLS Regression of Sexual Attitudes on Gender and Controls (HC1 Robust Standard Errors)

	Premarital Sex		Extramarital Sex		Same-Sex Relations	
	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3	Model 4	Model 5	Model 6
Female	-0.142^{***}	-0.145^{***}	-0.113^{***}	-0.103^{***}	0.096^{***}	0.085^{***}
	(0.008)	(0.008)	(0.005)	(0.005)	(0.007)	(0.007)
Gender ideology (std.)		-0.011^{*}		0.038^{***}		-0.045^{***}
		(0.004)		(0.003)		(0.004)
Age	-0.036^{***}	-0.035^{***}	0.003^{**}	0.001	-0.041^{***}	-0.039^{***}
	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.001)
$\text{Age}^2/100$	0.017^{***}	0.017^{***}	-0.005^{***}	-0.004^{***}	0.030^{***}	0.028^{***}
	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.001)
Education (years)	0.012^{***}	0.011^{***}	-0.000	0.002^{*}	0.019^{***}	0.017^{***}
	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.001)
Married	-0.109^{***}	-0.109^{***}	-0.100^{***}	-0.101^{***}	-0.161^{***}	-0.160^{***}
	(0.010)	(0.010)	(0.007)	(0.007)	(0.009)	(0.009)
CCP member	-0.043^{***}	-0.045^{***}	-0.035^{***}	-0.028^{***}	-0.010	$-0.018^{\dagger}$
	(0.012)	(0.012)	(0.008)	(0.008)	(0.011)	(0.011)
Religious	$-0.021^{\dagger}$	-0.020	0.003	0.001	-0.069^{***}	-0.066^{***}
	(0.013)	(0.013)	(0.008)	(0.008)	(0.010)	(0.010)
Internet user	0.165^{***}	0.164^{***}	0.073^{***}	0.077^{***}	-0.011	$-0.016^{\dagger}$
	(0.011)	(0.011)	(0.007)	(0.007)	(0.009)	(0.009)
Urban residence	0.099^{***}	0.098^{***}	0.024^{***}	0.026^{***}	0.028^{***}	0.025^{**}
	(0.010)	(0.010)	(0.006)	(0.006)	(0.008)	(0.008)
Agricultural *hukou*	-0.052^{***}	-0.050^{***}	-0.018^{**}	-0.023^{***}	-0.045^{***}	-0.038^{***}
	(0.010)	(0.010)	(0.007)	(0.007)	(0.009)	(0.009)
Log income	0.008^{***}	0.007^{***}	0.002^{***}	0.003^{***}	0.000	-0.000
	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.001)
Wave FE			Yes			
Adj. R^2	0.173	0.173	0.027	0.029	0.121	0.123
N	78,206		78,206		78,206	

Note. OLS coefficients with HC1 robust standard errors in parentheses. Models 1, 3, 5 are baseline; Models 2, 4, 6 add the standardized gender ideology index. All models include wave fixed effects (not shown).
$^{\dagger}p < .10$; $^{*}p < .05$; $^{**}p < .01$; $^{***}p < .001$.

Table 3: Causal Mediation Analysis: Gender Ideology as Mediator of the Gender Effect

	Premarital Sex	Extramarital Sex	Same-Sex Relations
ACME	0.003*	-0.009***	0.011***
	[0.001, 0.005]	[-0.011, -0.008]	[0.009, 0.013]
ADE	-0.145***	-0.103***	0.085***
	[-0.161, -0.130]	[-0.114, -0.093]	[0.072, 0.098]
Total Effect	-0.142***	-0.113***	0.096***
	[-0.158, -0.128]	[-0.123, -0.103]	[0.083, 0.109]
Proportion Mediated	-2.0%	8.4%	11.8%
$\tilde{\rho}$ at ACME = 0	-0.010	0.050	-0.050

Note. Causal mediation analysis following Imai et al. (2010a). 1,000 bootstrap replications. 95% confidence intervals in brackets. ACME = average causal mediation effect; ADE = average direct effect. $\tilde{\rho}$ is the sensitivity parameter: the correlation between mediator and outcome model residuals at which the ACME reaches zero (Imai et al., 2010b).
$^{*}p < .05$; $^{**}p < .01$; $^{***}p < .001$.

Table 4: Gender-Stratified OLS Models: Gender Ideology and Sexual Attitudes (HC1 Robust SEs)

	Premarital Sex		Extramarital Sex		Same-Sex Relations	
	Men	Women	Men	Women	Men	Women
Gender ideology (std.)	0.006	-0.038^{***}	0.053^{***}	0.019^{***}	-0.017^{**}	-0.055^{***}
	(0.007)	(0.006)	(0.004)	(0.003)	(0.005)	(0.005)
Age	-0.036^{***}	-0.034^{***}	0.004^{**}	-0.001	-0.033^{***}	-0.045^{***}
	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.002)	(0.002)
Education (years)	0.013^{***}	0.011^{***}	0.004^{**}	0.001	0.013^{***}	0.016^{***}
	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.001)
Married	-0.128^{***}	-0.075^{***}	-0.131^{***}	-0.068^{***}	-0.144^{***}	-0.197^{***}
	(0.015)	(0.014)	(0.011)	(0.008)	(0.013)	(0.012)
CCP member	-0.082^{***}	0.031	-0.051^{***}	0.010	-0.066^{***}	0.068^{***}
	(0.016)	(0.021)	(0.010)	(0.013)	(0.013)	(0.020)
Religious	-0.003	-0.039^{*}	0.018	-0.013	-0.054^{***}	-0.060^{***}
	(0.020)	(0.016)	(0.014)	(0.009)	(0.016)	(0.013)
Internet user	0.198^{***}	0.123^{***}	0.100^{***}	0.053^{***}	-0.012	-0.017
	(0.016)	(0.015)	(0.011)	(0.009)	(0.012)	(0.012)
Urban residence	0.106^{***}	0.084^{***}	0.039^{***}	0.011	0.041^{***}	0.013
	(0.014)	(0.014)	(0.010)	(0.008)	(0.011)	(0.012)
Agricultural *hukou*	-0.052^{***}	-0.039^{**}	-0.036^{***}	-0.006	-0.047^{***}	-0.048^{***}
	(0.015)	(0.014)	(0.010)	(0.009)	(0.012)	(0.013)
Log income	0.013^{***}	0.004^{***}	0.003^{*}	0.003^{***}	-0.002	0.000
	(0.002)	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.002)	(0.001)
Wave FE			Yes			
N	38,348	39,858				

Note. OLS coefficients with HC1 robust standard errors in parentheses. Each column is a separate regression estimated within the indicated gender subsample. All models include age^2/100 and wave fixed effects (not shown).
$^{\dagger}p < .10$; $^{*}p < .05$; $^{**}p < .01$; $^{***}p < .001$.

Figures

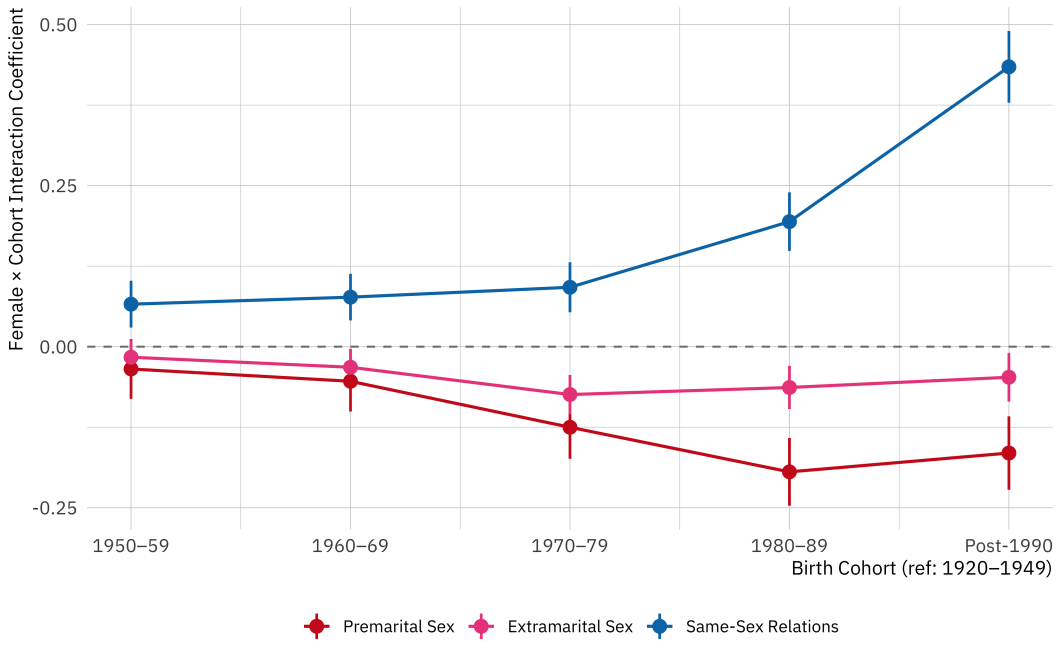

Figure 1: Cohort-linked divergence in the gender gap: Female × Cohort interaction coefficients (reference: 1920–1949 cohort). Lines connect successive cohorts; whiskers show 95% confidence intervals (HC1 robust). The post-1990 cohort shows the strongest divergence for same-sex attitudes ($b = 0.456$, $p < .001$). Corresponding estimates are reported in Table S2 (Supplementary Materials).

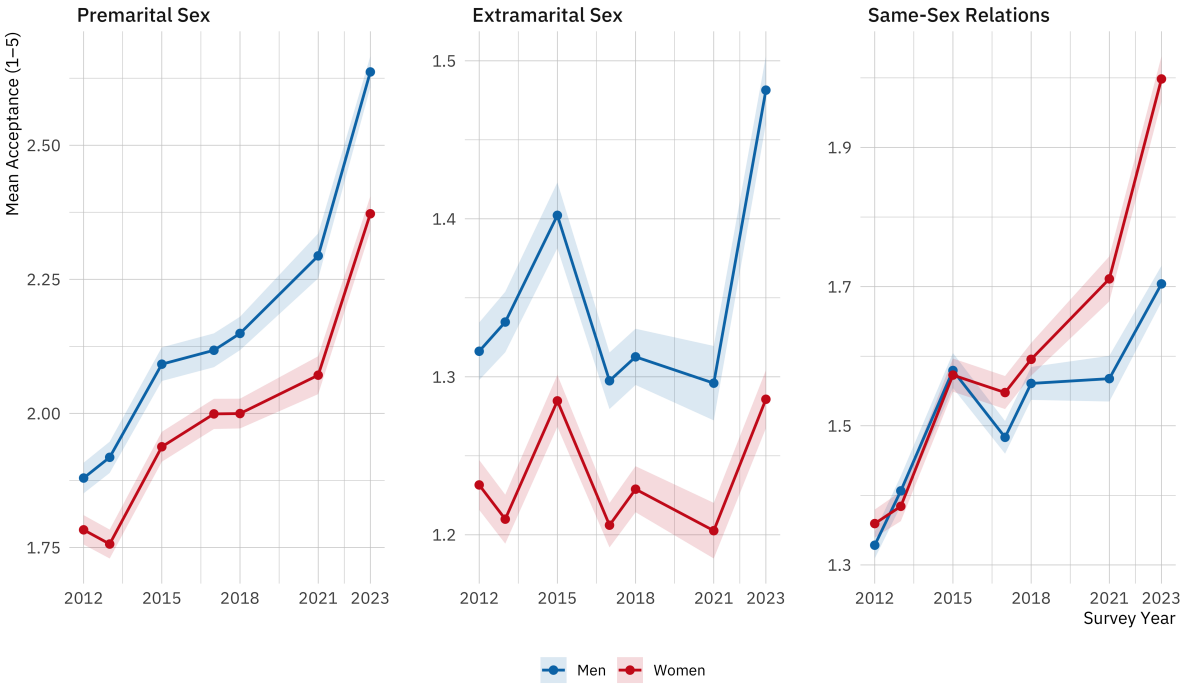

Figure 2: Mean sexual attitude acceptance by gender and survey year, 2012–2023. Each panel shows one domain of sexual attitudes measured on a 1–5 scale. Shaded bands show 95% confidence intervals of the mean. Source: CGSS 2012–2023 pooled data (N = 78,206).

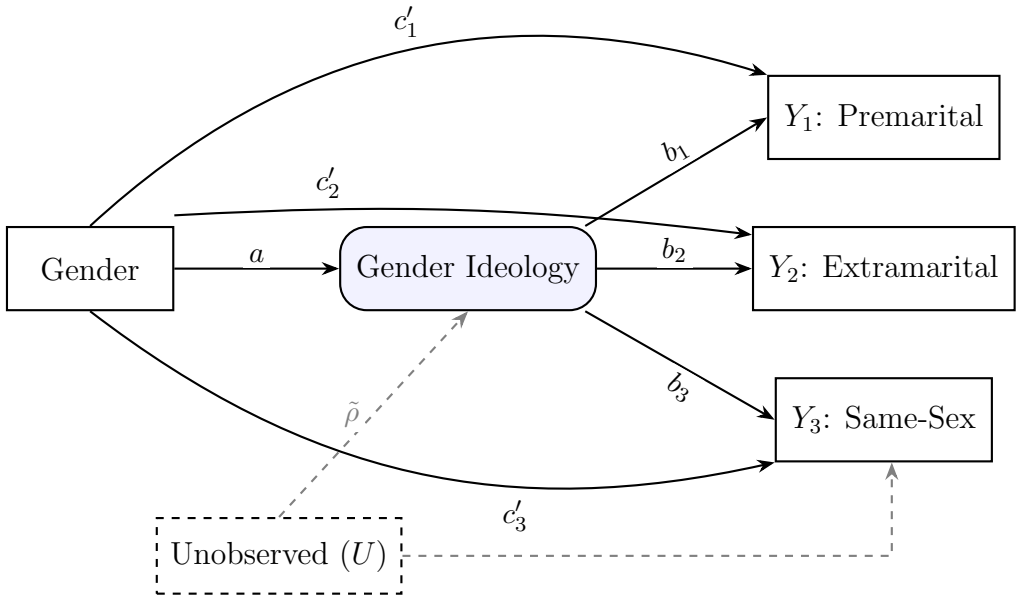

Figure 3: Domain-specific causal mediation model. Gender (X) influences sexual attitudes (Y_1, Y_2, Y_3) both directly (paths c_k') and indirectly through gender ideology (M; paths $a \times b_k$). Path coefficients from OLS with HC1 robust SEs. Dashed lines denote sensitivity to unobserved confounding (U; $\tilde{\rho}$ values in Table 3). $^{*}p < .05$; $^{***}p < .001$.

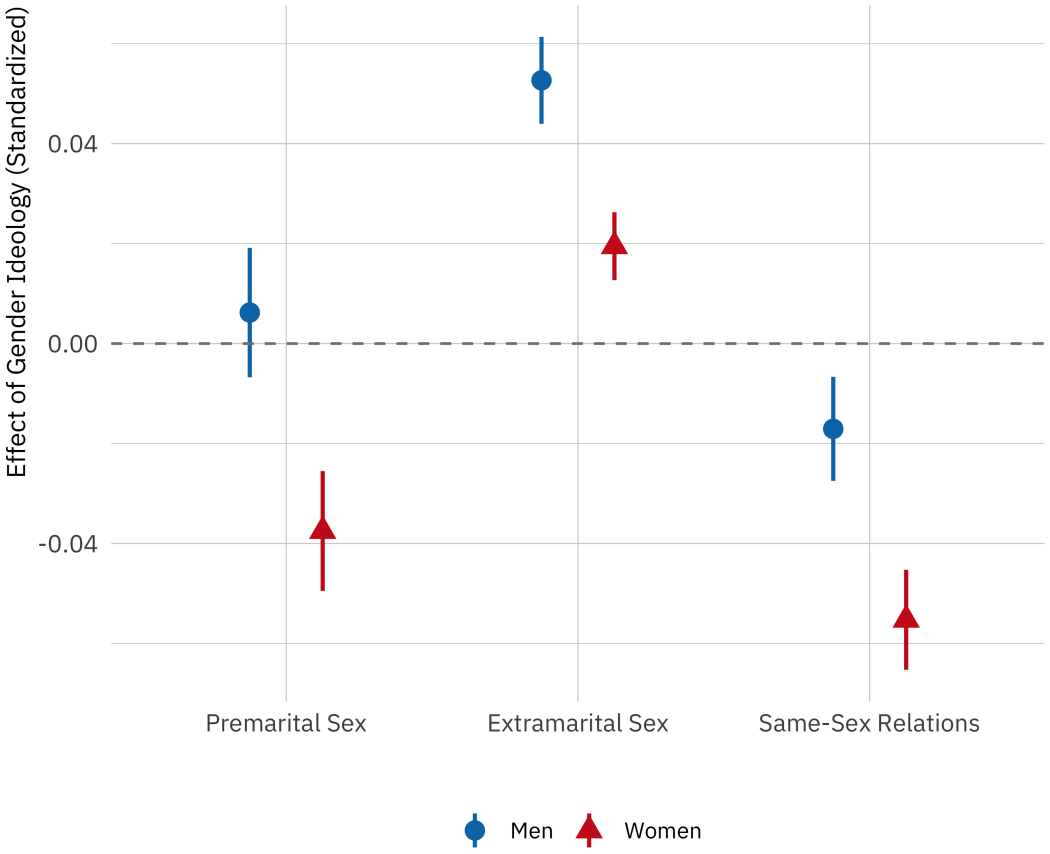

Figure 4: Effect of gender ideology (standardized) on sexual attitudes, by gender. Points show OLS coefficients; bars show 95% confidence intervals (HC1 robust). The domain-specific pattern reveals the sexual double standard: patriarchal ideology increases men's tolerance of extramarital sex but decreases women's tolerance of premarital sex.

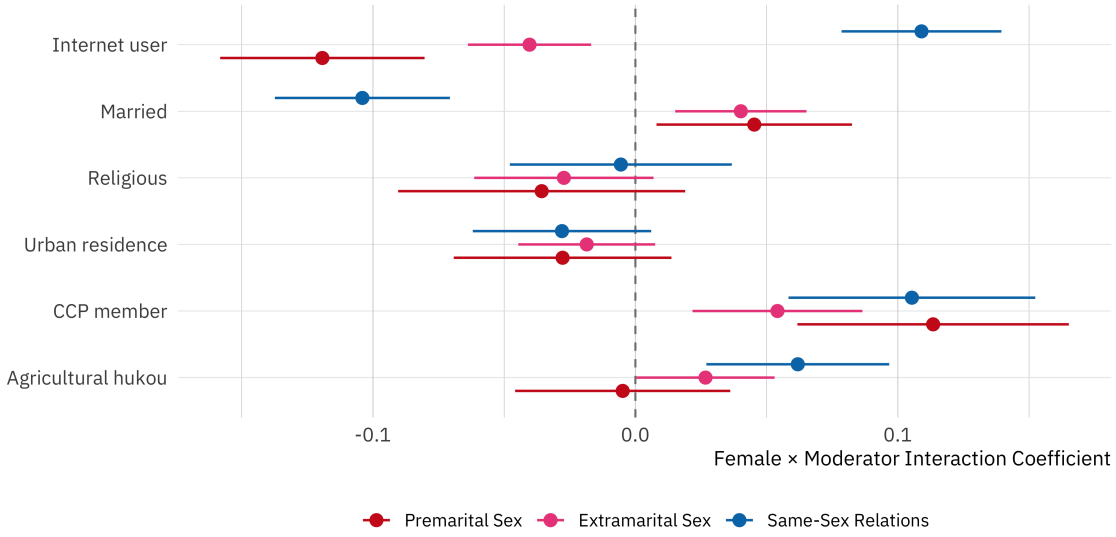

Figure 5: Heterogeneity in the gender gap: Female × Moderator interaction coefficients for six binary moderators across three attitude domains. Points show OLS coefficients; whiskers show 95% confidence intervals (HC1 robust). All coefficients come from a single OLS model per domain that includes all nine interactions simultaneously. Continuous moderators (education, GDP per capita, provincial college rate) are shown via Johnson-Neyman plots in Figure 6. Full estimates in Table S1 (Supplementary Materials).

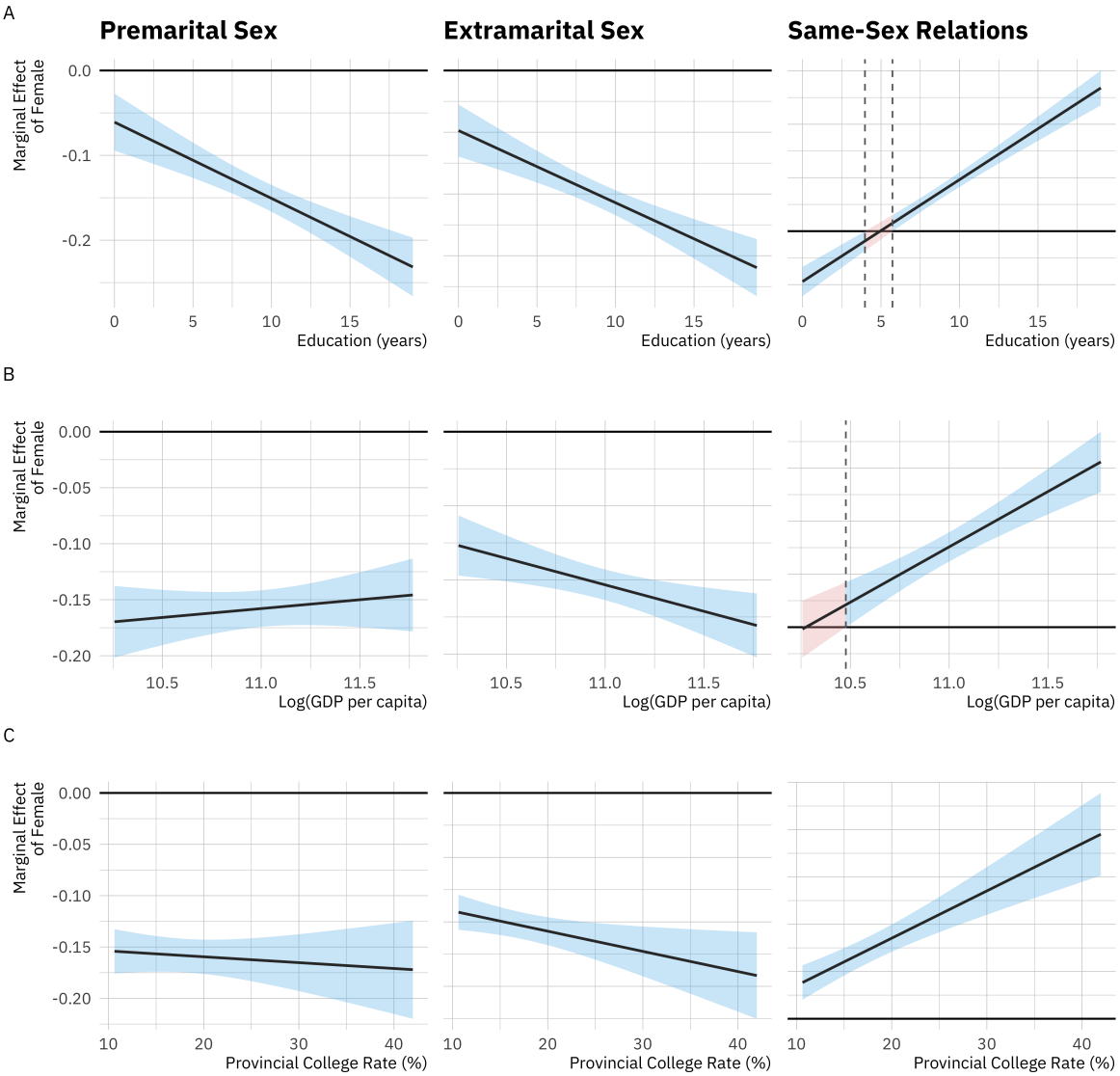

Figure 6: Johnson-Neyman plots: marginal effect of Female on sexual attitudes across continuous moderators. Shaded bands show 95% confidence intervals (HC1 robust). **(A)** Individual education (years): the same-sex gender gap turns positive at approximately 10 years of schooling. **(B)** Provincial GDP per capita (log): the same-sex gap turns positive in wealthier provinces. **(C)** Provincial college rate (%): same pattern. GDP per capita from China Statistical Yearbook (2017); college rates from 2020 Population Census. Full interaction estimates in Table S1 (Supplementary Materials).